

# Sustaining Change

Chapter 9 — Making Change Stick

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# Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- **Define** the concept of sustaining change versus implementing change.
- **Analyze** the causes of "Change Decay" and regression.
- **Evaluate** frameworks for sustainability (Lewin, Kotter).
- **Apply** strategies to embed change into Business As Usual (BAU).
- **Understand** the role of measurement and reinforcement systems.

# What is Sustaining Change?

Many organizations declare victory too early.

## Definition

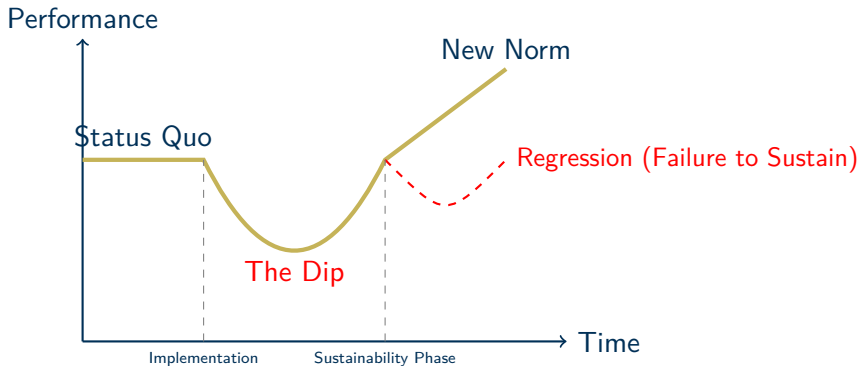
Sustainability is the process of ensuring that new ways of working become the "new norm." It is when the change persists without the need for constant special attention or project support.

## The Difference:

- **Implementation:** Installation of the new system/process.
- **Sustainability:** Realization of the benefits over the long term.

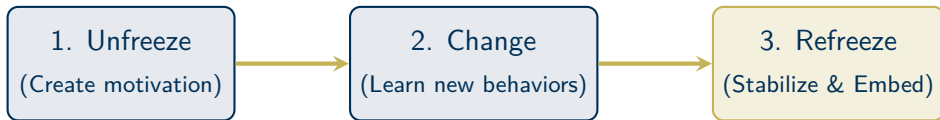
# The Challenge: The Performance J-Curve

Sustainability is dealing with the dip and ensuring the rise is permanent.



# Theoretical Basis: Lewin's Refreezing

Kurt Lewin's model remains the foundation of sustainability.



Without Refreezing,  
the organization snaps  
back to its original shape  
like a rubber band.

## Kotter's 8th Step: Anchoring Change

Kotter argues that change is not finished until it sinks into the **Culture**.

### Key Principles

- **Culture comes last, not first:** You change behavior first; when people see it works, the culture shifts to accept it.
- **Succession:** Ensure the next generation of leaders supports the change.
- **connection:** Explicitly show people how the new behaviors led to the recent success.

# Why Change Fails to Stick

- **Change Fatigue:** Too many initiatives lead to exhaustion.
- **Premature Victory:** Leaders celebrate "Go-Live" and move on to the next project immediately.
- **Turnover:** Key champions leave the organization.
- **Misaligned Incentives:** Asking for collaboration but rewarding individual performance.

## The "Evaporation" Effect

The tendency for focus and energy to dissipate once the project team disbands.

# Mechanisms for Embedding Change

How do we lock it in?

## Structural Levers:

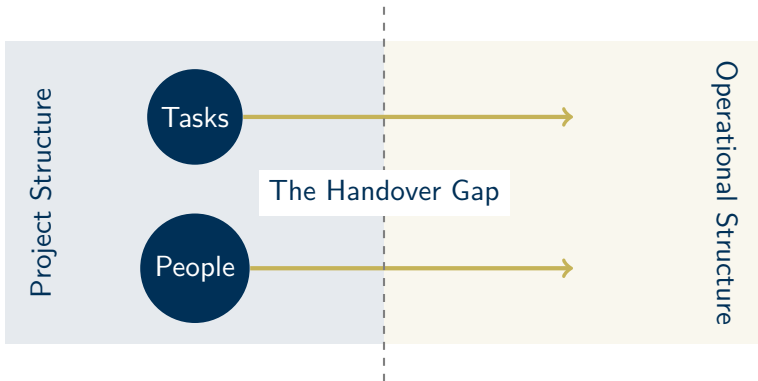
- **Rewards:** Bonuses/Promotions linked to new behaviors.
- **Recruitment:** Hiring people who already fit the new model.
- **Systems:** Hard-coding the process into IT systems.

## Psychological Levers:

- **Rites of Passage:** Promoting new champions.
- **Storytelling:** Creating myths about the new success.
- **Role Modeling:** Leaders walking the talk.

## Transition: From Project to Business As Usual (BAU)

The handover is a critical risk point.



*Sustainability requires Line Managers to take ownership from Project Managers.*

## Measurement: Keeping Score

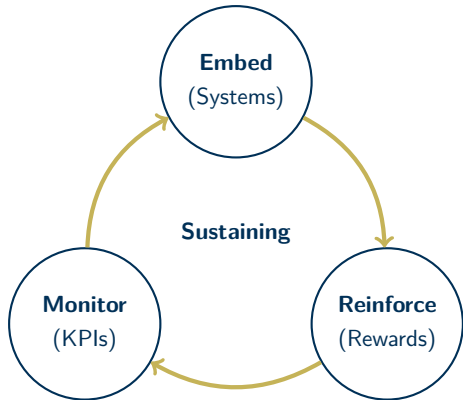
"What gets measured gets done."

- **Lagging Indicators:** Financial results (Profit, ROI). These come too late to correct course.
- **Leading Indicators:** Behavioral adoption (e.g., % of staff using the new software daily).

### Continuous Feedback Loop

Measurement is not just for judgment; it is for learning. If adoption drops, investigate *why* rather than just punishing.

# The Sustainability Cycle



1. **Embed:** Integrate into HR and IT.
2. **Reinforce:** Celebrate and reward adoption.
3. **Monitor:** Check for regression and adjust.

## Summary:

1. Sustainability is the act of preventing regression and embedding the "New Norm."
2. It requires moving beyond the project phase to **Business As Usual**.
3. Leaders must align **Incentives** and **Culture** to support the change.
4. **Measurement** provides the data needed to keep the change on track.

**Thank You**

Questions?